

Activity 7 — Spotify — Reading a Scaling Model Honestly

Course Fast-Track Innovations with Agile Design Thinking and Generative AI (GenAI)

WSQ Course Code TGS-2024049781

Topic Topic 03: Agile Development and AI for Rapid Solution Delivery

Duration 45 minutes · Group size: 3–5 participants

Tools Padlet Classroom Board, ChatGPT or Microsoft Copilot

Learning Outcome Addressed

LO3 · A7 · K5 — Agile frameworks for managing innovation projects; project management tools and techniques.

The Real Case

In 2012 Henrik Kniberg and Anders Ivarsson published a paper describing how Spotify organised engineering into Squads, Tribes, Chapters and Guilds. It spread worldwide as 'the Spotify Model' and was copied by hundreds of organisations. What most of those organisations missed was the disclaimer in the paper itself: it was a snapshot of a journey, not a framework, and Spotify had already moved on. Kniberg later stated plainly that Spotify does not use 'the Spotify Model' and that people should not copy it. Organisations that copied the structure — renaming teams 'squads' and departments 'tribes' — routinely failed to copy the culture of trust and autonomy that made it work, and ended up with the same hierarchy under new labels. The lesson: practices without principles are a short-lived Band-Aid.

Your Scenario

Your management team has returned from a conference and wants to 'implement the Spotify Model' across three departments by the end of the quarter. You have been asked to write the implementation plan.

What You Will Do

Learners examine the most-copied agile scaling model in the industry and diagnose why structural copying fails, then distinguish the transferable principles from the non-transferable artefacts — the core skill in leading design thinking and agile projects across an organisation.

What you will produce

A Padlet board separating Spotify's transferable principles from its non-transferable structures, and a one-page counter-proposal to the 'implement it by Q4' instruction.

Step-by-Step Instructions

1. Rejoin the Padlet classroom board and open the Activity 7 section.
2. Read the Spotify case in the Learner Guide (Activity 7) with your group.
3. In the sub-section 'Structures', post the parts of the model that are organisational artefacts.
4. In the sub-section 'Principles', post the underlying beliefs that made those artefacts work.
5. Ask ChatGPT: 'What conditions must be true in an organisation for autonomous squads to outperform a functional hierarchy?' and evaluate its answer critically.
6. Draft your counter-proposal: one team, one quarter, one measurable outcome. Post it.
7. Read another group's counter-proposal and comment with the biggest risk you see in it.

Discussion Questions

1. Spotify's own authors say do not copy it. Why did hundreds of organisations copy it anyway?
2. Separate the list: which parts of the model are structures (copyable) and which are cultures (not directly copyable)?
3. 'Practices without principles are a short-lived Band-Aid. And principles without practices are a fruitless exercise in philosophy.' Give a workplace example of each failure mode.
4. Your management wants it done by Q4. Write the one question that reframes the request without being insubordinate.
5. How might GenAI help you assess organisational readiness before a rollout — and what would it get wrong?

How You Know You Are Done

Your board cleanly separates structure from principle, and your counter-proposal names one team, one outcome and one metric rather than an organisation-wide rollout.

Debrief — What the Room Should Conclude

Renaming a department a 'tribe' changes nothing; devolving budget authority to it changes everything. The copyable parts are the visible artefacts — squad names, chapter structures, guild meetings. The parts that actually generated the results are autonomy backed by real decision rights, alignment through a clear mission, and a tolerance for teams choosing different practices. Those cannot be installed by reorganisation chart. The professional move when handed 'implement it by Q4' is not refusal but reframing: ask what outcome the leadership team actually wants — faster delivery, better retention, fewer handoffs — and then propose the smallest change that could plausibly move it, run in one team first. PremierAgile's guidance applies directly: start small, low-risk and high-value, one to three attempts before scaling.